

Will AI Replace Accountants?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

5.2

AI EXPOSURE · AUDIT / CPA ADVISORY

where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.



Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in an accounting degree or training, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study accounting" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether you are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where accounting sits in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. Accounting isn't one destination, it's a wide spread of them, from 5.2 to 7.9, and almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Where you land inside that range is decided mostly by moves still in front of you — chiefly, whether you steer toward the license. The second half of this guide is those moves.

And one thing specific to accounting. The route into this profession has changed more in the last eighteen months than any other in the index — and not because of AI. The profession is in the middle of rewriting its own entry requirements. Whatever you were told about how to qualify when you started, check it — it has probably moved since.

The short answer

Accounting remains one of the more defensible business-family degrees — but only if the destination is the license.

Audit and CPA advisory work scores 5.2 out of 10. Bookkeeping and transactional accounting scores 7.9.

The CPA signature is a legal monopoly no software can hold. Everything below it is among the most automatable work we score, and much of it automated long before generative AI existed.

And there's a second story here that has nothing to do with technology: the profession is running a severe shortage and has just spent two years dismantling its own biggest barrier to entry. Between the protected licensed tier and the exposed rung beneath, where you land is

decided mostly by moves still in front of you — which is the whole reason being already in it is not a problem.

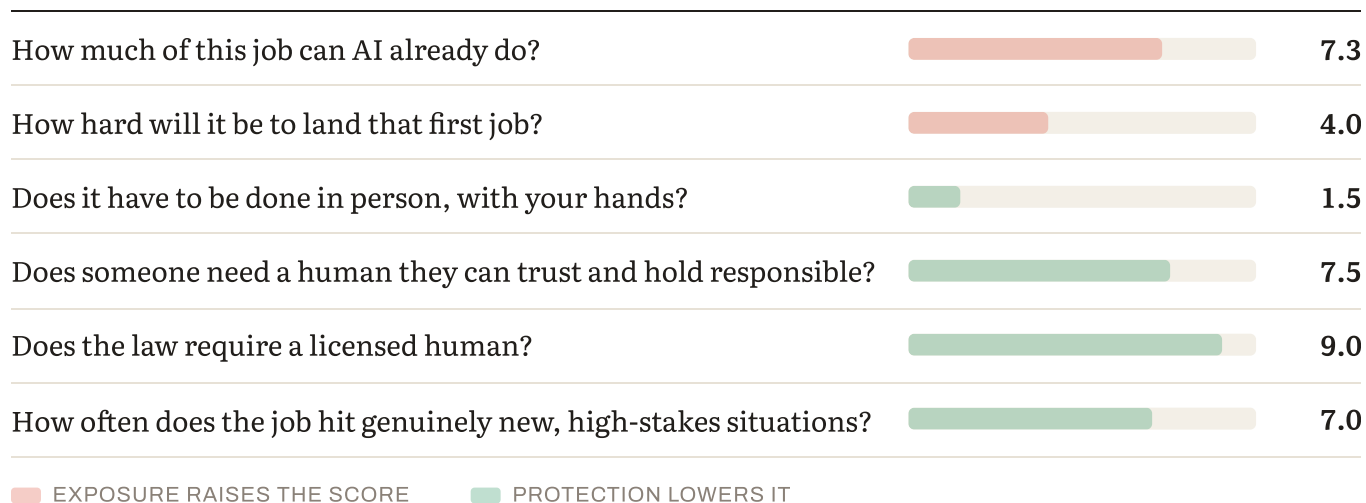
The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Audit / CPA advisory	4.4	4.8	5.2	+0.8	Moderate
Tax advisory (complex)	4.8	5.2	5.6	+0.8	Moderate
Management accounting / controller	5.5	6.0	6.3	+0.8	Moderate– High
Routine tax preparation	6.1	6.6	7.0	+0.9	High
Bookkeeping / transactional	6.8	7.4	7.9	+1.1	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, a business analyst scores 7.6, an entry finance analyst 8.0, and bedside nursing 2.8.

Read the table this way — and note where it starts. Bookkeeping was already at 6.8 in 2023. Data entry, reconciliation and categorisation were among the first white-collar tasks automated anywhere, and that displacement is mature rather than emerging. What generative AI added was speed at the top of that curve, not the curve itself. Your job, from here, is to move up the table toward the license — not to hope the table moves.

Why accounting scores the way it does — the six factors



Here's how audit and CPA advisory work answers them. Knowing *why* the licensed tier holds at 5.2 while the transactional tier sits at 7.9 is what tells you which way to move.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

A great deal — and accounting is unusual in scoring only moderately despite it.

Data entry and categorisation. Reconciliation and matching. Standard reporting and close processes. Routine tax return preparation. Workpaper assembly. Compliance checking against known rules. Audit sampling and testing.

We rate this **7.3**. What holds the overall score at 5.2 despite that is almost entirely regulatory protection and accountability — which makes accounting the clearest case in the index of a license carrying a profession.

What resists: signing the audit opinion, judgment on an ambiguous accounting treatment, advising a business owner on what to actually do, and professional skepticism — knowing when the numbers are wrong. Those are the things to be building toward.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Good, and getting better — which is almost unique in this index.

Two things protect it. The CPA pathway **mandates supervised experience hours, so firms have an institutional reason to keep hiring and training juniors** even where the work could be automated. And the profession is running a severe shortage: BLS projects more than **120,000 accounting and auditing openings annually** against roughly 55,000 graduates.

The section on the profession widening its own door, below, covers the third thing.

But "easy to enter" hides a fork worth seeing now. The same shortage that makes hiring easy is easiest of all at the transactional rung — the bookkeeping and routine-preparation work that scores 7.9 and 7.0 and is furthest into automation. Landing there because a seat is open is not the same as landing in the career. The way through is to aim at the licensed pathway — public practice, an audit seat, the supervised hours that count toward the CPA — rather than at whichever rung happens to be hiring fastest. A door being open at the bottom is not the same as a future there.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

Almost none of it. Accounting is text and numbers in, judgments out. There is no physical component to protect it.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the licensed tier, absolutely.

An audit opinion is a statement a named professional stands behind, with personal and professional liability attached. Liability is a legal construct, not a technical one — no capability transfers it. Which means the fastest way to become protected is to get closer to the seat that carries it.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

For the audit signature, comprehensively — and the section on the license that protects the training explains why this license works differently from law's.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

More than the stereotype suggests. Ambiguous treatments, unusual transactions, and the judgment call on whether something is materially misstated. Routine compliance work, by contrast, is the opposite. The distance between those two is the distance you're trying to close.

The license that also protects the training

This is the section worth carrying to other careers, because accounting's license does something most don't.

Compare three professions.

Law reserves the courtroom appearance and the signed advice. It says nothing about who reads forty thousand documents — so when that work became automatable, nothing stopped it, and junior law now scores 7.9 with an entry-path rating of 9.5.

Nursing reserves clinical practice *and* mandates the supervised hours required to qualify. The on-ramp is protected by the same statute that protects the job, which is why nursing rates 2.0 on entry-path erosion.

Accounting sits between them, and closer to nursing than most people realize. The audit signature is a legal monopoly — a public company's financial statements must be signed by a licensed CPA, with liability attached. But the CPA pathway also requires supervised professional experience, which gives firms a structural reason to employ juniors regardless of what the technology can do.

That's why accounting rates **4.0** on entry-path erosion rather than business's 7.5 or junior law's 9.5. The on-ramp has narrowed. Licensure props it open.

The general lesson: ask what a license reserves, and whether it reserves the training as well as the practice. Those are different protections, and for someone entering a field the second one matters more.

The thing that changed, and it isn't AI

Accounting has spent the last two years rewriting how people qualify, and it materially changes what you should do next.

For four decades, becoming a CPA required **150 credit hours** — effectively a fifth year of university beyond a standard bachelor's degree. Introduced in 1983 to raise the profession's standing, it became its biggest barrier to entry: an extra year of tuition, plus a year of foregone salary, at a moment when students were already weighing debt carefully.

The consequences were severe and are well documented. Accounting enrollments declined for over a decade. CPA exam participation fell to its lowest level since 2006. Roughly **300,000 accountants left the profession in five years**, and the AICPA/NASBA Trends Report shows a workforce increasingly concentrated in later-career age groups.

So the profession changed the rule. Around **43 states** have now altered or removed the 150-hour requirement, creating alternative pathways — commonly a standard bachelor's degree plus two years of supervised experience, rather than a fifth year of study plus one.

Why this matters more than it sounds. A profession that is deliberately widening its entry route, at the same moment most professions are narrowing theirs, is an unusual thing to find in this index. It is the entry-path factor moving in the opposite direction to everywhere else.

Two honest caveats. Legislative change is slow, and licensure numbers will take years to respond. And the reform doesn't touch the other reason students choose elsewhere, which is

covered below.

The practical instruction: check the current requirements in the specific state or country where you intend to qualify. They have probably changed since the last time you looked — and if you're mid-degree, the cheaper, faster route to the license may now be open to you.

What the trend shows

Audit / CPA advisory: 4.4 → 4.8 → 5.2. Up 0.8.

Bookkeeping: 6.8 → 7.4 → 7.9. Up 1.1, from an already elevated base.

The gap widened from 2.4 points to 2.7. What is distinctive here is how *early* the bottom of this profession was automated. Most careers in this index show a sharp change after 2023. Accounting's transactional tier was already substantially displaced before generative AI arrived, and this is the closest thing we have to a preview of what maturity looks like: not collapse, but a tier that quietly stopped being a career.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Regulatory / licensing	Strong and narrow	Most durable	The audit signature is statutory. But it reserves specific acts — unreserved work is unprotected.
Human trust / accountability	Strong at licensed tier	Durable	Someone must stand behind the opinion and carry liability.
Judgment under novelty	Moderate	Eroding	Ambiguous treatments resist; rule application does not.
Physical / embodied	None	n/a	Accounting has never had this.

The honest read. Accounting's protection is real, narrow, and entirely attached to the license. The tier above it inherits some by proximity. The tier below it has none — which is why 5.2 and 7.9 sit in the same profession, and why the direction you steer matters more than where you happen to start.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Entering and reconciling transactions	Already gone
Preparing the workpapers	Reviewing generated workpapers
Sampling and testing	Testing the full population, automatically
Preparing routine returns	Checking prepared returns
Learning the client by building their numbers	Learning them... some other way
Forming the opinion and signing it	Unchanged

Two things worth naming.

Audit is changing more fundamentally than the score suggests. When testing moves from a sample to the whole population, the auditor's job stops being "check a selection" and becomes "investigate the exceptions the system flagged." That is a more interesting job and a different skill.

And the training problem is real here too. Generations of accountants learned a client's business by assembling its numbers. That was tedious and it was also the education. The AICPA has begun work to redefine what early-career accountants need to know — which is a professional body formally acknowledging that its own entry-level competence has changed. Which means the accountants who go out of their way to understand the business — not just produce its numbers — have an edge that's about to get scarcer.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Professional skepticism** — knowing when the numbers are wrong, or when a plausible explanation isn't the true one. The most valuable and least automatable thing here.
2. **Accountability** — being the licensed human who signs.
3. **Judgment on ambiguity** — where the standard permits more than one treatment and someone has to choose.
4. **Advisory judgment** — telling a business owner what to actually do, not what the numbers say.
5. **Verification** — knowing when generated workpapers or a generated return are subtly wrong.

Notably absent: speed and accuracy of processing, and volume of transactions handled. These were the traditional markers of a strong junior and are entirely automated. If your current value is mostly on that second list, the work is to shift it onto the first.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability**. The specific tools — the audit platform, the tax engine, the reconciliation software — will turn over many times across a career. The accountants who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious about how a business works and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they trained on. In a profession where the entry-level tasks are automating fastest, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and increasingly it's what firms are hiring for: the trajectory toward the signature, not the current processing skill.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The shortage is severe, well documented, and works entirely in your favor.

- **More than 120,000 annual openings** projected by BLS, against roughly 55,000 graduates
- Somewhere around **190,000–200,000 open accounting positions** at any given time
- **Roughly 300,000 accountants left the profession in five years, and the remaining workforce skews late-career** — meaning a retirement wave on top of an already-thin pipeline
- Starting salaries rising in response, with Robert Half projecting a further 3.7% increase into 2026
- The first real signal of recovery: a **12% increase in undergraduate accounting enrollment** in spring 2025

What accountants report as rewarding: genuine breadth of exposure to how businesses actually work, a qualification that travels internationally better than almost any other business credential, a clear and well-marked path to seniority, and — distinctively — that practice ownership is a realistic and common destination.

And the CPA is unusually portable. It opens finance leadership, advisory, forensic work, industry controllership and consultancy. Few credentials transfer this widely.

What's genuinely hard about it

The salary gap at entry is the profession's real problem, and it is the reason students choose elsewhere.

A first-year audit associate typically earns **\$55,000–\$70,000**. A first-year financial analyst earns **\$75,000–\$95,000**. A first-year software engineer earns **\$90,000–\$130,000**. **These are the same students, from the same universities, and the gap has widened every year.**

Busy season is real. January through April in tax and audit is genuinely punishing, every year, and it is the single most-cited reason people leave for industry roles.

The fifth-year cost, where it still applies. Where the 150-hour rule persists, the extra year carries \$15,000–\$50,000 in tuition plus a year of foregone salary.

And the perception problem is self-reinforcing. Accounting is seen as rigid and stressful, which shrinks the pipeline, which increases the load on those who stay, which reinforces the perception.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Accounting tends to suit people who:

- **Are genuinely comfortable with detail** — not tolerant of it, comfortable in it
- **Like understanding how businesses work** from the inside
- **Are skeptical by temperament** — the professional core is not taking things at face value
- **Want a clear qualification and a marked path**, which accounting provides better than most business routes
- **Are willing to trade early salary for later optionality**

It's harder for people who:

- Want **high early earnings** — that comparison is the profession's weak point
- Need **variety over rhythm**; the annual cycle is fixed
- Find **detail work draining** rather than absorbing
- Dislike **seasonal intensity**

If some of that second list sounds like you, it isn't a reason to abandon the path — it's a reason to steer toward the parts of it that fit, and to get to the license that gives you optionality, which is what the rest of this does.

What else is moving this market

The pipeline crisis dominates everything, and it is demographic rather than technological. Every year of below-replacement graduates compounds it.

The 150-hour reform is the most significant structural change in the profession in forty years, and it is still working through state legislatures.

Offshoring is a real factor at the transactional tier and worth naming honestly — much of the work automation didn't take has moved rather than disappeared.

And there's a paradox worth sitting with. The shortage is severe and the entry tier is automating at the same time. Both are true because they are happening at different levels: the profession needs licensed CPAs badly and needs bookkeepers barely at all. Anyone who reads "accounting shortage" as a general green light has misread it — the shortage is a shortage of licensed accountants, and that is the tier to aim at.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

The situation: accounting is further into this than most professions. Audit software, automated reconciliation and AI-assisted tax preparation are established rather than emerging. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a live internship or first job, which is exactly where it counts.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE ACCOUNTANT LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Verify.** Knowing when generated workpapers or a prepared return are wrong. In audit this is professional skepticism applied to a machine rather than a client, and it is the same underlying skill.
- 2. Work with full-population testing.** When you can test everything rather than sample, the job becomes investigating exceptions. That is a different and more interesting skill than the one accountancy training has historically built.
- 3. Advise rather than report.** The reporting layer is automating; the "what should we do about this" layer is not. Every step toward advisory improves the score.
- 4. Understand the client's business.** This used to arrive automatically from building their numbers. Now it has to be pursued deliberately — and it's what separates someone who can sign from someone who can only prepare.

5. Get to the license. Everything in this guide points there. The pathway has just become shorter in many states; use that.

All five are available to you now — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where an accounting qualification can lead later

Unusually broad, and this is one of accounting's strongest arguments: public practice partnership, financial controllership and CFO tracks, advisory and transaction services, forensic accounting and investigation, internal audit and risk, tax specialism, industry finance leadership, and business ownership.

The pattern in this index holds: roles closer to the signature and to accountability score better. Management accounting sits at 6.3 rather than 5.2 precisely because nobody outside the business relies on it in the way they rely on an audit opinion. That pattern is the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Accounting is a 2.7-point spread from 5.2 to 7.9, and where you land inside it is decided mostly by things still in front of you. Nearly all of them point the same way: toward the license.

If you're still in the degree or training

Three levers, in order of leverage.

1. The license is the whole game. The transactional core — bookkeeping (7.9) and routine tax preparation (7.0) — is the exposed end and is furthest into automation already. The protected destinations — audit and CPA advisory (5.2), complex tax advisory (5.6) — are reached by the license, not by the general or transactional route. If you haven't committed to the CPA pathway, this is the single highest-leverage decision left. And check the current requirements where you intend to qualify: around 43 states have changed or removed the 150-hour rule, and the cheaper, faster route may now be open to you.

2. Audit and assurance depth, while it's still free. This is where the regulatory protection lives. Coursework light on audit is training for the exposed tier. Take audit and assurance seriously rather than as the dull option, and learn full-population testing and audit technology now — that is the version of the job that ages well, and it is far cheaper to acquire in the degree than to bolt on later.

3. The internship, and the supervised hours it leads to. The profession recruits through internships and conversion rates are high given the shortage. That is the experience that separates the protected licensed tier from the exposed floor — and it's the on-ramp to the supervised hours that count toward the CPA. Secure one, then convert it, and go into public practice first: the reverse — industry first, then practice — rarely works.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the title on the offer matters more than it looks, because the most common early-career accounting titles are also the most exposed.

- **"Bookkeeping" and "routine tax preparation" roles are the 7.9 and 7.0.** They're everywhere in the shortage and they're the automating layer at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Aim at audit and assurance, and complex tax advisory (5.2, 5.6).** Public practice with a path to the signature is the protected lane; proximity to the opinion someone stands behind is proximity to the protection.
- **Get onto the licensed pathway.** A first role that generates supervised hours toward the CPA is worth more than a better-paid one that leads nowhere near the license. A seat that pays now but doesn't count toward the signature is choosing the 7.9 tier, however it's titled.
- **Chase the seat closest to the signature.** Audit over back-office processing, advisory over reporting — even at a smaller firm, where responsibility and client contact tend to arrive sooner.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't undo the tasks that are already automating, but you can be the accountant who directs these tools rather than competes with them. The five capabilities above — verify, work with full-population testing, advise rather than report, understand the client's business, get to the license — are all available right now, inside a current internship or a first job. The most powerful for someone already in it is verification: be the person who catches the generated workpaper or the prepared return that's subtly wrong. In audit that is professional skepticism aimed at a machine

rather than a client — the same underlying skill, and the one the licensed tier is built on. You can start building it this term, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in accounting is built here, in these habits and choices, rather than handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree or training; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree / training — build toward the license

- **Treat the license as the product, not the degree.** The protection in accounting lives at the licensed tier (audit / CPA advisory 5.2, complex tax advisory 5.6), not in the transactional core (routine tax prep 7.0, bookkeeping 7.9). Aim every choice at the signature.
- **Check the current CPA requirements where you intend to qualify.** Around 43 states have changed or removed the 150-hour rule; the route you were told about may no longer be the route, and a cheaper one may be open.
- **Choose audit and assurance depth over general business content.** That is where the regulatory protection sits. Coursework light on audit is training for the exposed rung.
- **Secure the internship — then convert it.** The profession recruits through internships and conversion rates are high given the shortage. It is the single strongest early signal, and the on-ramp to the supervised hours.
- **Get fluent with audit and tax technology as a professional, not a shortcut.** Learn full-population testing and how to review AI-prepared workpapers and returns — verification is the skill that survives.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The tools will turn over repeatedly; the accountant who re-tools fastest, and stays genuinely interested in how a business works, compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Public practice versus industry, the management-accounting route, apprenticeship and school-leaver routes — vet them properly, and remember the order in which you enter them matters.

During the job hunt — aim for the signature, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Audit and assurance, complex tax advisory, public practice with a path to the CPA — not "any accounting role," which too often points at the 7.9 rung.
 - **Read the title, not just the offer.** Bookkeeping and routine tax-preparation roles are the automating layer (7.9 and 7.0). If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
 - **Don't grab a role just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. A firm still running a large bookkeeping or routine-preparation intake may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung that gets cut first once it catches up. Availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
 - **Go into public practice first.** That is where the supervised hours and the license come from; the reverse — industry first, then practice — rarely works.
 - **Prefer the seat closest to the signature.** Audit and assurance over back-office processing, advisory over reporting — proximity to the opinion someone stands behind is proximity to the protection.
 - **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** Whether they're building the job around full-population testing and advisory work, or waiting to be forced to, tells you if the seat grows or is quietly being hollowed out.
 - **Weigh trajectory over starting salary.** The entry salary gap is real; the answer to it is the license and where it leads, not chasing the highest first-year number into an exposed lane.
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Go deeper — further reading

- **Accountants and Auditors — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — US Bureau of Labor Statistics. Primary source and free: projected openings, wage distributions and entry requirements. The 120,000-plus annual openings figure comes from here.
- **Tracking CPA licensure paths: removing the 150-hour hurdle** — CFO Dive. The clearest account of the licensure reform: which states have moved, what the new pathways look like, and why the profession did it.
- **120 vs 150: understanding the new CPA licensure pathways** — the practical version of the same story: the three pathways as they now stand. Read this before assuming anything about how qualification works from here.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest case against our score is demographic, and it is genuinely strong.

Roughly 300,000 accountants left in five years. CPA exam participation is at its lowest since 2006. Openings outnumber graduates by more than two to one. On this reading, AI isn't displacing accountants — it is the only thing preventing a staffing crisis, and a score of 5.2 for the licensed tier badly understates how secure the work actually is.

Where we land: we think this is right about the licensed tier and wrong about the tier below it, which is why we score tracks rather than professions. A shortage of licensed CPAs raises the value of the licensed path — exactly what this guide recommends aiming at. It does very little for bookkeeping and transactional work, where the retiring workforce is being replaced by software and offshoring rather than by people.

The specific thing we're watching: whether graduate hiring at the large firms rises or falls as the 150-hour reforms take effect. If firms hire more juniors because the pathway is cheaper, our entry-path score comes down and we'll say so.

Bottom line

Accounting is one of the better business-family choices, and the license is the whole argument — which is exactly why being already in it is not a problem. The decisive moves were always going to happen from here.

The CPA signature is a legal monopoly, and unlike law's bar card, the pathway to it mandates supervised experience — which props open the on-ramp that most professions are losing.

The transactional tier beneath it is not a career any more, and hasn't been for longer than the AI conversation has existed. Bookkeeping scored 6.8 back in 2023. Standing still on that rung is the one thing not to do.

And the most important recent change has nothing to do with technology. Around 43 states have altered or removed the 150-hour requirement, which is a profession deliberately widening its own door at exactly the moment most are narrowing. If you started before 2025, the route to the license may now be shorter than the one you planned for — check it.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. Treat the license as the product, not the qualification you happen to hold. Steer toward audit and assurance depth over general or transactional work. Go into public practice first, because that's where the supervised

hours and the signature come from. And build real AI fluency — verification above all — inside whatever role you're in now, because that's the differentiator this profession rewards.

And one honest thing about the trade-off: the entry salary gap is real, it is substantial, and it is the profession's genuine weakness. What accounting offers in exchange is a license, a shortage, and a door that is currently getting wider rather than narrower — which is a rarer combination than it sounds, and it's still available to you from where you stand.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in it or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which track are you on — or aiming at — and does it point at the license *and* the signature (audit, CPA advisory) or at processing (bookkeeping, routine returns)? 2. Looking at the score table, which destination are you currently pointed at, and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 3. **Have you checked the current CPA requirements where you'd qualify?** They've changed in most states, and if you started before 2025 the route may be shorter than you think.

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected seat you could realistically aim for from where you are now — audit, assurance, complex tax advisory — and what would make you a credible candidate for it? 5. If you're still studying: how much compulsory audit and assurance are you actually taking, and is there more you could add before it's no longer free? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you aiming at a licensed pathway on purpose, or applying to whatever's open? Does the first role you're chasing generate supervised hours toward the CPA?

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — verify, full-population testing, advise rather than report, understand the client's business, get to the license — which one could you visibly demonstrate within the next few months? 8. Can you point to a moment where you caught a generated workpaper or a prepared return that was subtly wrong? If not, where's the easiest place to start building that skill?

Testing it against reality

9. **The most valuable single action:** find someone three to five years into public practice and ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that work still exists. 10. If the first offer that comes is a bookkeeping or routine-preparation role, what's your plan — take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, or hold out for something closer to the signature? Decide before the offer, not after.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For accounting specifically, the licensure requirements described here are changing state by state — verify current rules before making any decision based on them.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Accounting

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment})\end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
--------	--------

- | | |
|------|---|
| 0–2 | Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel. |
| 3–4 | Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence. |
| 5–6 | A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup. |
| 7–8 | A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role. |
| 9–10 | Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard. |

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
--------	--------

- | | |
|------|---|
| 0–2 | Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated. |
| 3–4 | Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives. |
| 5–6 | Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced. |
| 7–8 | Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone. |
| 9–10 | The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer. |

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
--------	--------

- | | |
|------|--|
| 0–2 | Fully screen-based. Location-independent. |
| 3–4 | Occasional presence; the core work is not physical. |
| 5–6 | Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions. |
| 7–8 | Substantially physical, with some variability of setting. |
| 9–10 | Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time. |

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

AUDIT / CPA ADVISORY — 5.2 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.9	6.9	7.9	2.77
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.2	3.6	4.0	0.6
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	8.5	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.5	9.5	9.5	0.05
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.3
				Total	5.21 → 5.2

TAX ADVISORY (COMPLEX) — 5.6 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.6	7.5	8.5	2.97
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	4.0	4.4	0.66
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.0	8.0	8.0	0.3
Regulatory / licensing	10%	9.0	9.0	9.0	0.1
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.3
				Total	5.61 → 5.6

MANAGEMENT ACCOUNTING / CONTROLLER — 6.3 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.1	7.4	8.0	2.8
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.5	5.0	5.5	0.82
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.45
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.0	4.0	4.0	0.6
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.35
				Total	6.3 → 6.3

ROUTINE TAX PREPARATION — 7.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.9	8.1	9.1	3.18
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.0	6.5	0.97
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.35
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.55
				Total	7.01 → 7.0

BOOKKEEPING / TRANSACTIONAL — 7.9 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.6	8.0	9.2	3.22
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.5	7.2	7.8	1.17
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.0	4.0	4.0	0.9
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.0	3.0	3.0	0.7
Judgment under novelty	10%	3.5	3.5	3.5	0.65
				Total	7.92 → 7.9

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Audit / CPA advisory

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	5.9	3.2	1.85	4.4
2025	6.9	3.6	1.85	4.8
Fall 2026	7.9	4.0	1.85	5.2

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.70** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.8** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.